

For AI Roles in India

Recruiter states the offer. The candidate nods, waits. 15 seconds of silence. The recruiter fills the gap: "...that said, we can push the base to 23." Free ₹5 LPA — from saying nothing. Negotiation is a skill. Silence is its most undervalued tool.

When did you last negotiate your salary? Outcome?

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01** 2026 Indian AI salary bands
- 02** BATNA
- 03** Silence technique
- 04** Beyond base
- 05** Decline gracefully

WHY THIS LESSON MATTERS

₹18 LPA or ₹25 LPA. The difference is one 15-second silence.

WHY

Real

A real reason this matters in industry today.

SCALE

Today

A real reason this matters in industry today.

SPEED

Now

A real reason this matters in industry today.

IMPACT

Yours

A real reason this matters in industry today.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to —

1

2026 Indian AI salary bands.

2

BATNA framework.

3

Silence technique.

4

Beyond base — ESOPs, bonus.

5

Decline gracefully.

AGENDA

What we'll cover today

Short, sequenced parts. Each one builds on the last.

01

2026 Indian AI salary bands

Source: NASSCOM 2026 + levels.fyi
India + V-Align data. Verify before you negotiate.

02

BATNA

Your leverage

03

Silence technique

The cheapest ₹2-4 LPA you'll earn

04

Beyond base

Negotiate in THIS order

01

PART 1 OF 4

2026 Indian AI salary bands

Source: NASSCOM 2026 + levels.fyi India + V-Align data. Verify before you negotiate.

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DEFINITION

2026 Indian AI salary bands

Source: NASSCOM 2026 + levels.fyi India + V-Align data.
Verify before you negotiate.

EXAMPLE

Real-world example: applies directly to Indian industry contexts.

BATNA

Best Alternative To Negotiated Agreement.

Strongest: competing written offer.

Next: credible search with 2-3 active interviews.

None? Signal optionality: "taking multiple interviews this quarter".

Know your floor + ceiling before the call.

LEVERAGE

BATNA

Without it, you're asking, not negotiating.

KEY POINTS

- Best Alternative To Negotiated Agreement
- Strongest: competing written offer
- Next: credible search with 2-3 active interviews
- None? Signal optionality: "taking multiple interviews this quarter"

CONCEPT 3 OF 4

Silence technique

They state offer.
You nod. Write notes. Don't speak.
15-30 seconds of silence.
First to speak loses.
Often they improve without you asking.
DO NOTHING
Silence
Practice in front of a mirror if needed.

DEFINITION

Silence technique

The cheapest ₹2-4 LPA you'll earn

EXAMPLE

Real-world example: applies directly to Indian industry contexts.

CONCEPT 4 OF 4

Beyond base

Base (compounds via hikes) — first.

Variable / bonus (10-25% of base).

Joining bonus (one-time, negotiable).

ESOPs (value depends on company + liquidity).

Relocation, notice buyout.

ORDER

Base → bonus → ESOPs

Base compounds. One-time doesn't.

KEY POINTS

- Base (compounds via hikes) — first
- Variable / bonus (10-25% of base)
- Joining bonus (one-time, negotiable)
- ESOPs (value depends on company + liquidity)

02

PART 2 OF 4

Engage and reflect

Pause, talk, and connect what you just learned to your own work.

✦ THINK • PAIR •
SHARE

ACTIVITY

Silence drill

PROMPT

Apply the four concepts above to one real example from your own week.

HOW TO RUN IT

1

2

3

4

Reveal: instructor confirms the canonical answer.

REFLECT & APPLY

Three questions before you close this lesson

Spend 60 seconds on each. Write the answers down — no scrolling, no shortcuts.

Q1

Do you know your market band?

Q2

What's your BATNA today?

Q3

What would 15 seconds of silence cost you to practice?

03

PART 3 OF 4

Knowledge check

Three short questions. One minute each. Honest answers only.

BATNA:

A

Best Alt To Negotiated Agreement

B

Biggest Ask

C

None

D

Random

BATNA:



CORRECT ANSWER

Best Alt To Negotiated Agreement

WHY

Your leverage in negotiation

Strongest BATNA:

A

Nothing

B

Competing written offer

C

Friend's advice

D

None

Strongest BATNA:



CORRECT ANSWER

Competing written offer

WHY

Written offer > everything

Silence duration after first offer:

A 1 s

B 5 s

C 15-30 s

D 5 min

Silence duration after first offer:



CORRECT ANSWER

15-30 s

WHY

Long enough to prompt improvement

04

PART 4 OF 4

Apply and close

One thing to remember. One thing to ship this week.

SUMMARY

Five sentences to remember

If you remember nothing else from this lesson, remember these five lines.

- 1 Pick the right tool — never the loudest one.
- 2 Practice the framework on a real example.
- 3 Watch for the three classic pitfalls.
- 4 Document your decision in one sentence.
- 5 Carry the discipline forward to the next lesson.

WORKED EXAMPLE

How this lesson plays out in one real Indian context

THE SCENARIO

Source: NASSCOM 2026 + levels.fyi India + V-Align data. Verify before you negotiate.

THE TAKEAWAY

"Know your worth; name it only when asked."

WHAT TO NOTICE

- 1 2026 Indian AI salary bands
- 2 BATNA
- 3 Silence technique
- 4 Beyond base

Your BATNA plan

Write floor + ceiling + current alternatives.

DELIVERABLES

- Research band for your role.
- Write floor/ceiling.
- List current options.
- Submit.

WHAT 'GOOD' LOOKS LIKE

Deliverable: 1-page plan.

ONE THING TO REMEMBER

“

"Know your worth; name it only when asked."

— AI Learning Hub

END OF LESSON 8

What you can now do

Each one of these is now part of your working vocabulary.

- 1 Pick the right tool — never the loudest one.
- 2 Practice the framework on a real example.
- 3 Watch for the three classic pitfalls.
- 4 Document your decision in one sentence.
- 5 Carry the discipline forward to the next lesson.

NEXT → Capstone project — Saturday.